

1981

Portable, Pretty, Popular, Personal!

April: The Laptop

The first commercially-successful portable computer, the Osborne 1, was launched by Adam Osborne, founder of the Osborne Computer Corporation (OCC). With that launch, the idea of bundling commercial software applications



The world's first "laptop"

with computers became the norm. This model came with the WordStar word processor, compilers for the CBASIC and MBASIC programming languages, and the SuperCalc spreadsheet application. Though the Osborne 1 included software worth \$2,000 (about Rs 1,08,000 now), it was shipped at a price of \$1,795 (about a lakh today). It was this aggressive pricing that made the Osborne 1 very popular, and it set the rules for PC marketing for years to come.

The Osborne 1 was designed to be rugged and easy to carry around. It was just as big as a mini-suitcase. This is also considered the first luggable PC, the ancestor of today's laptop. At its peak, the OCC sold ten thousand units in a month. Its only shortcoming was its tiny, 5-inch screen. This was necessitated by the two floppy drives on either side of the screen.

The keyboard folded into the casing, just like the top of a briefcase. It had an optional battery pack. Due to the small screen, you could only view 52 characters of text per line. You could, however, use the navigation keys to scroll left and right when the screen displayed 128 characters. The laptop ran the CP/M operating system.